ChicoSol conversation guide

Wednesday, Nov. 11, 2026 | Scotty Franzyshen | Personal notes for a conversation with Katherine Kihiczak

The point to leave with Katherine

My question is whether our response has become better at administering homelessness than preventing it or getting people into stable housing. I have lived through the system, and I want the results examined, not just the intentions.

A natural 45-second introduction

“I spent more than ten years experiencing homelessness in Chico. I have stayed in local shelters, navigated services, worked and volunteered. In September I finally obtained a room ... but housing still takes roughly 68% of my income. That is how close to the edge a person can remain even after getting housed. I am not saying every program or worker has failed. I am asking whether the system gives people a realistic route into housing they can keep. The campout is one way to get neighbors talking about that.”

The Chico Campout for Compassion ... Saturday, Nov. 14

• One Night. Many Locations. One Community. A decentralized community awareness event, not a central campsite.

• Not a fundraiser. Its purpose is conversation, learning, listening to lived experience and understanding barriers to housing.

• No one has to sleep outside. Individuals, families and organizations can participate through discussions, shared information, small gatherings or voluntary sleepouts in permitted places.

• Not a simulation of homelessness. People who participate for one night can go home afterward; people experiencing homelessness often cannot.

• Invitation, not instruction. Participants can bring different perspectives. The aim is to replace stereotypes with actual conversations.

Why this matters now

The Nov. 4 town hall discussed a proposed city homelessness plan; it was not simply a report on already-adopted policies. ChicoSol reports a City Council discussion is expected Nov. 17, and the Warren Settlement expires Jan. 14, 2027. The questions are what changes, who is affected, and what outcomes are measured.

Things to say from your own experience

• “A shelter bed is not the same as a home. Shelter can be valuable and its staff can genuinely help ... but it is not always the right fit for every person.”

• “My experience is evidence of how the system feels from below. The city records should tell us how the system performs overall.”

• “I care about safe parks and safe neighborhoods too. Moving people from one location to another does not, by itself, reduce the number without housing.”

The six stages ... my interpretation, not a proven conspiracy

Use the graphic as a set of research questions. It describes a possible reinforcing cycle, not proof that any person or organization deliberately designed every step.

Stage	What the graphic argues	What a reporter could verify
1. Restrict affordable housing	Housing policy and development leave lower-income needs unmet.	RHNA targets vs. permits and completed units, income categories, approvals and barriers.
2. Create housing insecurity	Rents and low incomes make losing housing more likely.	Rents, wages, cost burden, eviction data, applicant demand, and prevention outcomes.
3. Make homelessness a public enemy	Public attention centers on visible disorder instead of the housing shortage.	Compare official statements and news narratives with public data and affected residents' accounts.
4. Channel anger into enforcement	Displacement becomes a visible response.	Enforcement spending, citations, clearances, destinations afterward, changes in housing status.
5. Finance service systems	Contracts, shelters and administration expand while housing is still scarce.	Public contracts, budgets, provider reports, independent audits, contract requirements and results.
6. Manage without ending	Activity is measured more often than sustained housing exits.	Total people served vs. permanent placements, retention after 6/12 months, repeat homelessness.

The critical distinction

"I am not saying every organization is corrupt, or that government secretly planned homelessness. I am saying policies, funding and public narratives may reinforce one another. If we want to challenge that interpretation, let's test each stage against records and outcomes."

Three investigative leads to put on the table

• Production: Compare Chico's housing needs by income category with actual permitted and completed affordable units over several cycles.

• Money and outcomes: Trace contracts and program spending to permanent housing placements and retention, instead of counting only services delivered.

• Human consequences: Interview people affected by shelter rules, repeated displacement, rent barriers and successful housing transitions.

Evidence to bring up without overstating it

UCSF's California study found that housing costs had become unaffordable for many participants; their median household income in the six months before homelessness was $960/month. Chico's 2024 housing progress report lists 472 very-low-income and 232 low-income units permitted toward the current cycle, as of 2024; these figures are not current 2026 totals, nor do permits equal homes completed. Request an updated HCD report before stating a current total.

Ask Katherine: What records would help distinguish people served from people who got and kept permanent housing?

Your six-stage graphic

Reference visual for the discussion | A hypothesis to examine through budgets, policy records and lived experience

